Hockey: Canada’s Religion or Just a Game?

Target Audience: B1+ / B2 (Upper-Intermediate)
Time: 45-50 minutes
Approach: CLIL + Socio-cultural approach
Lesson Objectives:

- Educational (Content): Students will understand the cultural significance of hockey in Canada and its role in shaping national identity, as well as the social issues (cost, accessibility) surrounding the sport.
- Linguistic (Language): Students will practice vocabulary related to sports and society (e.g., *passion, identity, national sport, rivalry, religion*), and develop reading and speaking skills.
- Socio-cultural: Students will develop critical thinking by analyzing why a sport can become a "national religion" and compare the role of national sports in Canada with the students' home country (Dialogue of Cultures).

Stage	Stage aim	Timing	Procedure	Aids and materials
Warm-up	Activate background knowledge and introduce the concept of sport as identity.	5 min	Teacher shows a picture of a hockey game (NHL). Ask: *"What sport is this? Which country is famous for it? Why do you think sport is so important for a country's identity?"*	Presentation slide
Controlled Practice	Present target vocabulary and check understanding.	7 min	Vocabulary Match. Students match words with definitions: *passion, identity, national sport, rivalry, religion*. Prediction. Look at the title *"Hockey: Canada's Religion?"* Do you think the text will say hockey is just a game or something more?	Vocabulary Match, presentation slide.
Pre-Reading	Set the purpose for reading the text.	3 min	Skimming for Gist. Teacher asks: *"Some people say hockey is a 'religion' in*	Text Summit 72 | CBC

			*Canada. Do you think a sport can be a religion? Let's read to find out why."*Students have 1 minute to skim the text.	Documentaries , Breaking the Ice: Redefining and reimagining Canada's national sports | Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council , We bow our heads and play - The Globe and Mail , Scarborough Strong opens doors for young hockey players
Reading	Develop reading skills for detailed understanding.	10 min	Students read the text "Hockey: Canada's Religion?" carefully and complete the comparison table.	Text and Table
Freer Practice	Apply knowledge, develop speaking skills and critical thinking through the "Dialogue of Cultures"	15 min	Task 1: Round Table Discussion. Students work in small groups. They discuss questions, expressing their personal opinions and using arguments from the text. Task 2: Dialogue of Cultures. Compare the role of the most popular sport in Canada with the most popular sport in the students' home country.	Discussion Cards, board.
Homework and feedback	Summarize, consolidate, and reflect on cultural importance.	5 min	*"What is your favourite winter tradition in your country?"*	Notebooks

Match the words (1-5) with their definitions (A-E).

Word	Letter	Definition
1. Passion	[ ]	A. The state of being a country; who we are as a people.
2. Identity	[ ]	B. A strong feeling of enthusiasm or excitement for something.
3. National sport	[ ]	C. A situation where people compete strongly against each other.
4. Rivalry	[ ]	D. The most popular sport in a country, often a part of its culture.
5. Religion	[ ]	E. A system of faith and worship (often used metaphorically for something people are very devoted to).

1. B
2. A
3. D
4. C
5. E

Hockey: Canada’s Religion?

Perspective 1: The "Religion" View
For many Canadians, hockey is not just a game—it's a part of their soul. It is often said that hockey is Canada's national religion. Academics have even studied it as such, noting that the game gives fans a sense of awe and belonging to a larger community . As one researcher put it, *"I grew up in Peterborough, Ontario, where hockey is a religion"* .

Kids learn to skate before they learn to read. The famous 1972 Summit Series against the Soviet Union was not just a sports competition—it was a battle for national identity during the Cold War. As the CBC describes it, the series *"changed*

hockey forever, playing out dramas of national identity, pride, politics, and ideology while the world watched" . When Team Canada wins an Olympic gold medal, the whole country stops to watch. It unites people from different regions, languages, and backgrounds. For many, hockey is the thread that holds the country together.

Perspective 2: The "Just a Game" View
However, critics say hockey is not for everyone. It is very expensive. Equipment, ice time, and travel can cost thousands of dollars a year. In fact, it costs approximately $800 just to equip a child from head to toe . This means many immigrant families and low-income families cannot afford to play.

As some sociologists argue, hockey has become an *"elite sport"* . The image of the typical hockey player is often a young, able-bodied, white man, which can make others feel excluded . For them, hockey is just a game for the rich, not a national religion. The gap between the myth of "hockey for everyone" and the reality of high costs is a growing problem in Canada

Read the text and answer the questions.

1. Why do some academics compare hockey to a "religion" in Canada? (Give one example from the text).

   _____
2. _____
3. What was the significance of the 1972 Summit Series against the Soviet Union?

   _____
4. _____
5. How much does it cost just to equip a child with hockey gear from head to toe?

   _____
6. Why do critics say hockey has become an "elite sport"?

   _____
7. _____
8. According to the text, what image does the "typical hockey player" have, and why is this a problem?

Read the text "Hockey: Canada’s Religion?" and complete the table with information from the text.

Feature	**Perspective 1: The "Religion" View**	**Perspective 2: The "Just a Game" View**
Main Idea	Hockey is a national religion that unites the country.	1. _____ _____
Key Arguments & Examples	2. _____ _____ __	3.
Key Facts / Numbers mentioned	*(No specific numbers in this part)*	4. _____ _____
Who is it for?	Everyone: it unites people from different regions, languages, and backgrounds.	5. _____ _____

Work in groups of 3-4. Read the questions below and discuss them. Use the vocabulary from the lesson (*passion, identity, national sport, religion, elite*) and the arguments from the text.

Discussion Questions:

1. The "Religion" Debate: The text says hockey gives Canadians "a sense of awe and belonging." Why do you think people need sports to feel this way? Can a sport really replace traditional religion in modern society?
2. The "Elite" Problem: The text states that it costs about $800 just to buy equipment for a child. If a sport becomes too expensive, does it stop being a "national" sport? Should the government pay for poor children to play hockey?
3. The "Image" Problem: The text mentions that the typical hockey player is seen as a "young, able-bodied, white man." How does this stereotype affect the popularity of the sport? How can Canada make hockey more inclusive?

4. Dialogue of Cultures: What is the most popular sport in your country? Is it accessible to everyone, or is it also becoming an "elite" sport? Compare it to the situation in Canada.

Useful phrases for discussion:

- *From my point of view...*
- *I totally agree with the author because...*
- *I see your point, but I still think...*
- *That's a good point, however...*
- *For example, in my country...*